As Budgets Tighten, More People Are Dusting Off Their Library Cards

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When money gets tight, a lot of people reach for the same thing: a library card. Izzy Rivera, who lives in Topeka, Kansas, reads at least one book every week. But as she saves up for law school, buying new books is not always in her budget. "Say I'm buying a few a month," she said, "it just isn't realistic." So Rivera borrows books and digital copies from her local library through the Libby app. Last month she picked up 15 books for about $20 at her library's used book sale. "It's somewhere I can go where I'm not expected to spend money," she said. A Pew Research Center survey released in mid-October found that 44% of Americans say they have struggled in the past year to afford at least one basic **necessity**, and 70% said they have cut back on extras such as streaming **subscriptions**. Several of the largest public library systems in the country have reported recent rises in membership, borrowing and event attendance. Librarians say the rising cost of living is part of the reason. In Los Angeles, use of the library's **makerspace** grew 37%, while digital borrowing and visits were both up more than 20%. There is history behind the trend: library borrowing rose at 18 large systems during a brief U.S. **recession** in 2001. Libraries have also become places to borrow more than books. Many lend out Wi-Fi **hotspots**, cooktops, birding kits and camping gear, in what is often called a "library of things." At the same time, library **funding** is under pressure. Last year, the Trump administration tried to cut the federal Institute of Museum and Library Services, but 21 states sued and the grants were restored. Maria McCauley, president of the American Library Association, said libraries rely on a mix of federal, state and local **funding**.

Word Treasure

makerspace -- A makerspace is a room in a library where people can build and create things.

necessity -- A necessity is something you need to live, like food or a home.

subscriptions -- A subscription is a payment you make regularly to use a service.

hotspots -- A Wi-Fi hotspot lets devices connect to the internet without wires.

funding -- Funding is money given to pay for something.

recession -- A recession is a time when a country's economy shrinks.

Background you need

A public library is a place where anyone in a community can borrow books and use other services for free.

Libby is an app that lets library members borrow e-books.

A makerspace is a room where people can use tools and machines to build things.

When prices rise, free services become more valuable to families trying to save money.

Break it down

LEAD: More people are using libraries as budgets tighten
KEY EVENT: Rising library use across the United States
  +- WHO: Izzy Rivera, librarians and library users
  +- WHERE: Topeka, Los Angeles, Chicago and other cities
  +- WHY: Prices are rising and libraries are free
EVIDENCE: A Pew survey and library numbers show the rise
OPEN QUESTION: Will library funding stay secure?

Why it matters

Libraries give everyone free access to books, movies, tools and help, which matters most when money is tight.

Test what you remember

1. Where does Izzy Rivera live?

(A) Phoenix, Arizona
(B) Los Angeles, California
(C) Chicago, Illinois
(D) Topeka, Kansas

2. How many books did Rivera buy at the library's used book sale?

(A) 10 books for about $30
(B) 20 books for about $15
(C) 15 books for about $20
(D) 5 books for about $20

3. What did the Pew survey find?

(A) 70% of Americans moved to a new city
(B) 44% of Americans struggled to afford at least one basic necessity in the past year
(C) 44% of Americans stopped using libraries
(D) 70% of Americans bought more books

4. By how much did use of the Los Angeles library's makerspace grow?

(A) 8.1%
(B) 11%
(C) 20%
(D) 37%

5. What does a "library of things" lend?

(A) Wi-Fi hotspots, cooktops, birding kits and camping gear
(B) Clothes, shoes and hats
(C) Dogs, cats and rabbits
(D) Cars, boats and bicycles

6. What happened to the plan to cut the Institute of Museum and Library Services?

(A) 21 states sued and the grants were restored
(B) The plan was never announced
(C) The agency was closed down
(D) Libraries lost all their funding

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: B 4: D 5: A 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Izzy Rivera: says the library is a place where she is not expected to spend money
2. Maria McCauley, president of the American Library Association: says libraries rely on a mix of federal, state and local funding

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):